UNIT 2

Gender Roles and Relations

two or many? • discrimination • roles • matrix • missing women • sex ratio • spectrum

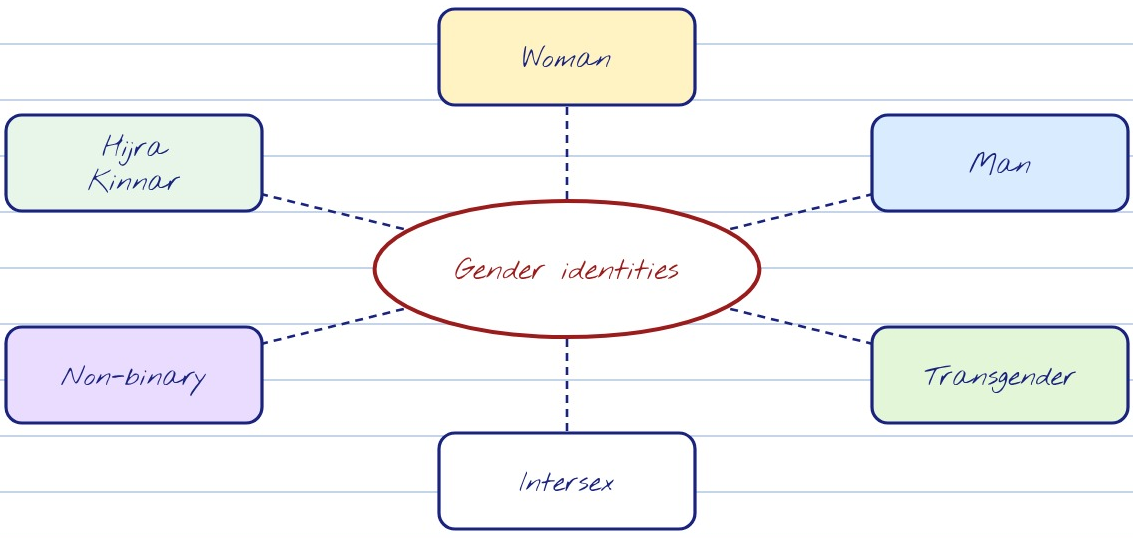
1. Two or Many? - The Gender Binary and Beyond

The **gender binary** is the belief that there are only two genders - man and woman - with fixed traits. Reality is wider: intersex persons, transgender persons, hijras, and many non-binary identities exist in every society and time.

Q1. Does gender have only two categories? Explain "Two or Many?".

Ans. No. Biologically sex is not always strictly two, and socially gender identity is a range.

- **Intersex** : born with chromosomes, hormones or organs that do not fit typical male or female.
- **Transgender** : gender identity differs from the sex assigned at birth (trans woman, trans man).
- **Hijra, Aravani, Kinnar, Jogta, Shiv-Shakti** : traditional third-gender communities of South Asia.
- **Non-binary or gender-queer or gender-fluid** : identify as neither or both or moving between.
- **Cisgender** : identity matches the sex assigned at birth.



Remember

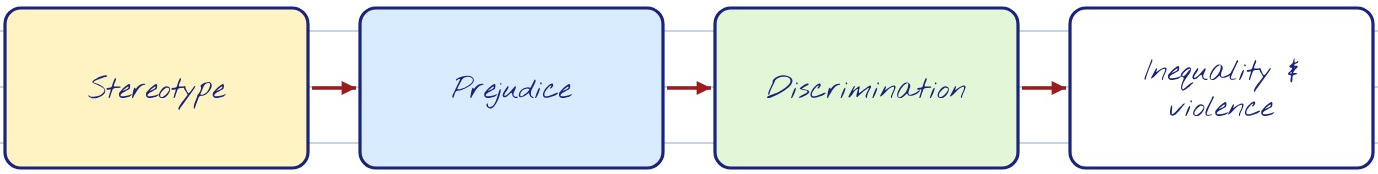
- Sex (body) is not the same as gender identity (mind) and sexual orientation (attraction).
- Third gender recognised by Supreme Court in **NALSA v. Union of India (2014)**; Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 gives right to self-perceived identity.

2. Struggles with Discrimination

Q2. What is gender discrimination? Where does it occur?

Ans. Unfair, unequal treatment or denial of opportunity to a person only on the ground of sex or gender.

- **Family** : son preference, unequal food, schooling & inheritance.
- **Education** : drop-out of girls, "boys' subjects".
- **Work** : wage gap, glass ceiling, unsafe workplaces, no promotion after maternity.
- **Public life** : low political representation, street harassment.
- **Law and custom** : personal laws, property, guardianship, honour codes.



Q3. Describe the struggles of women, transgender persons and others against discrimination.

- **Women's movements** : Savitribai Phule (girls' education), Raja Ram Mohan Roy (against sati), Pandita Ramabai, Begum Rokeya, Tarabai Shinde; later Chipko, Anti-dowry, Shah Bano and Mathura rape case campaigns, Me Too.
- **Law reform** : Hindu Succession (Amendment) Act 2005 - equal coparcenary right to daughters; Equal Remuneration Act 1976.
- **Transgender struggle** : recognition (NALSA 2014), end of criminalisation of same-sex relations (Navtej Singh Johar, 2018), welfare boards.
- **Global** : suffragettes, CEDAW (1979), Beijing Conference (1995).

Year	Milestone
1848	Seneca Falls Convention (USA) - women's rights
1979	CEDAW adopted by UN General Assembly
1993	India ratifies CEDAW; DEVAW declaration
1995	Beijing Platform for Action
2005	Daughters get equal coparcenary right (Hindu Succession Act)
2014	NALSA judgment - third gender
2018	Navtej Singh Johar - Sec. 377 read down

3. Gender Roles and Relations

Gender roles = behaviours, tasks and responsibilities a society expects from women and men. **Gender relations** = the power relations between them - who controls resources, decisions, time and body.

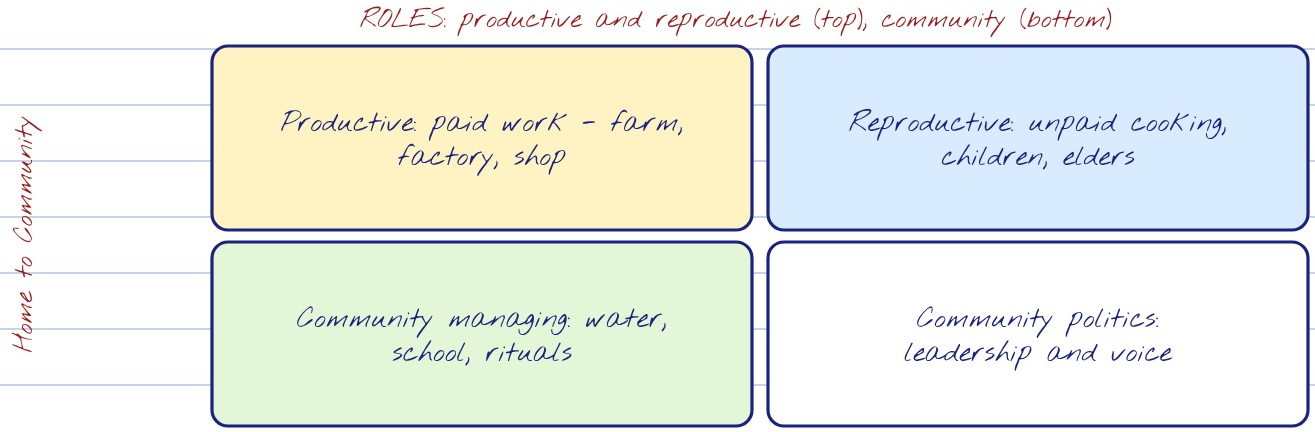
Q4. Define gender roles and gender relations. How are they different?

Gender roles	Gender relations
What women and men DO	How women and men RELATE (power)
Division of tasks	Access to and control over resources
Can be changed or swapped	Rooted in patriarchy, hard to change
Example : women cook, men earn	Example : men decide how income is spent

Q5. Explain the types of gender roles (Moser's triple role).

Ans. Caroline Moser described three kinds of work done by women and men.

- **Productive role** : work for pay or in kind - farming, factory, business (valued, counted).
- **Reproductive role** : childbearing, child-rearing, cooking, cleaning, care of old (unpaid, invisible).
- **Community managing role** : unpaid work to maintain community resources - water, health camps, festivals (mostly women).
- **Community politics role** : formal leadership, decision making, panchayat, party (mostly men).



Triple role of women (Moser)

Role categories at a glance

- **Traditional roles** : fixed by custom (women = homemakers, men = providers).
- **Modern roles** : shared - both earn, both care.
- **Reversed roles** : house-husbands, women breadwinners; show that roles are not "natural".
- **Role conflict** : working women carry the **double burden** (job + housework).

4. Gender Roles and Relationships Matrix

A **matrix** (like Harvard Analytical Framework) is a tool to record WHO does WHAT, who has ACCESS to and CONTROL over resources in a family or community.

Q6. What is the gender roles and relationships matrix? Draw and explain.

Ans. It maps activities, resources and decisions by gender to spot imbalance before planning a programme.

Activity or Resource	Women	Men	Access	Control
Cooking, cleaning, child care	Yes	Rare	Women	Women (low value)
Farm work, wage labour	Yes	Yes	Both	Men
Land, house, bank account	No	Yes	Men	Men
Mobile phone, vehicle	Limited	Yes	Men	Men
Community meetings, panchayat	Few	Many	Men	Men
Household income decisions	Few	Yes	Men	Men

- **Access** = can use a resource; **Control** = can decide about it and own it.
- Women often have access (they use) but no control (they don't decide).
- Use : planners design projects so that benefits reach women and decision power is shared.



5. Missing Women

Q7. What is meant by "Missing Women"?

Ans. Term of Nobel economist **Amartya Sen (1990)** : the number of women who should have been alive had they received equal care but are "missing" because of neglect, selective abortion and infanticide.

- In nature, more boys are born (~105 per 100 girls) but women live longer, so females should be slightly more.
- In India and China the ratio is lower - tens of millions of women "missing".
- Causes : female foeticide, infanticide, neglect in food, health care and education, dowry deaths, maternal mortality, violence.

> Missing women = Expected women - Actual women alive

6. Sex Selection and its Consequences

Q8. What is sex selection? Why does it happen?

Ans. Choosing the sex of a child before birth (pre-conception, pre-natal) or after birth (infanticide) - nearly always in favour of boys.

- **Son preference** : sons seen as heirs, old-age support, performers of last rites; daughters as "burden" (dowry, safety).
- Easy availability of ultrasound, small-family norm, patriarchy, poor enforcement of law.

Q9. What are the consequences of sex selection?

- Skewed sex ratio, shortage of brides -> forced marriage, bride trafficking, polyandry in some regions.
- More violence, sexual crimes, insecurity for girls, early marriage.
- Social problems : male surplus, loneliness, crime; harms women's health (repeated abortions).
- Long-term demographic imbalance.

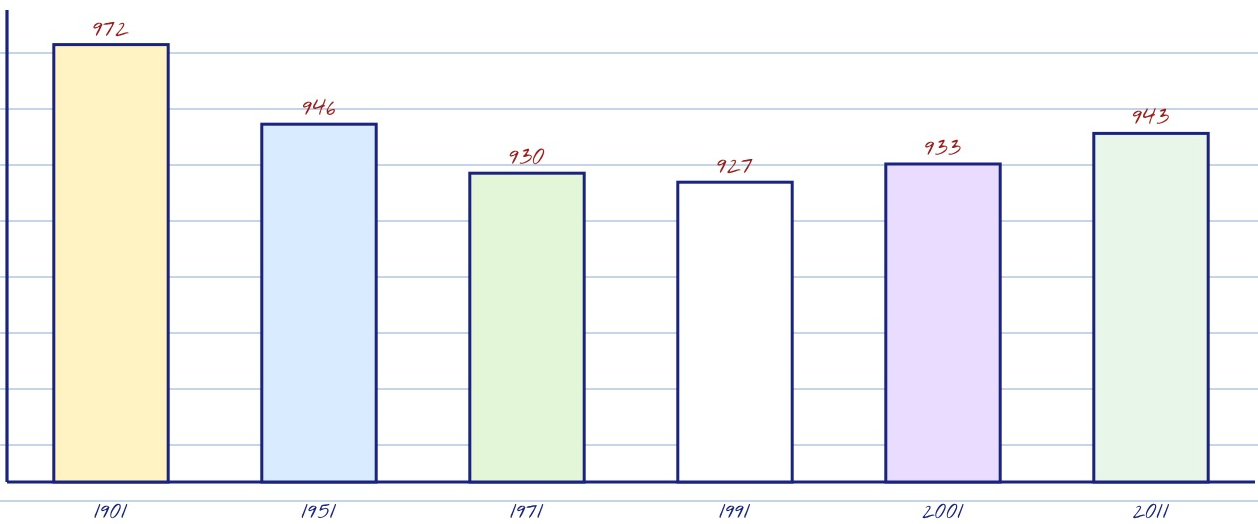
Laws and schemes against sex selection

- **PCPNDT Act, 1994** (amended 2003) : bans sex determination tests, advertisements; punishment to doctors and parents.
- MTP Act 1971 (amended 2021) : abortion only for specified reasons, not for sex.
- **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao** (2015), Sukanya Samriddhi Yojana, Ladli, Kanyashree schemes.

7. Declining Sex Ratio

Sex ratio = number of females per 1000 males. **Child sex ratio (CSR)** = females per 1000 males in age group 0-6 years.

India sex ratio (females per 1000 males, Census) (scale starts above zero)



Q10. What is the trend of child sex ratio in India?

Ans. CSR fell from 927 (Census 2001) to 919 (Census 2011) - the lowest since Independence, despite overall sex ratio improving.

- Lowest CSR states (2011) : Haryana, Punjab, Delhi, Chandigarh; best overall sex ratio : Kerala (1084); high CSR : Mizoram, Chhattisgarh.

› Reasons : sex-selective abortion, higher female infant mortality, neglect, migration of men.

8. Demographic Consequences

Q11. Explain the demographic consequences of a declining sex ratio.

› **Marriage squeeze** : fewer women of marriageable age, bride import from other regions, bride price.

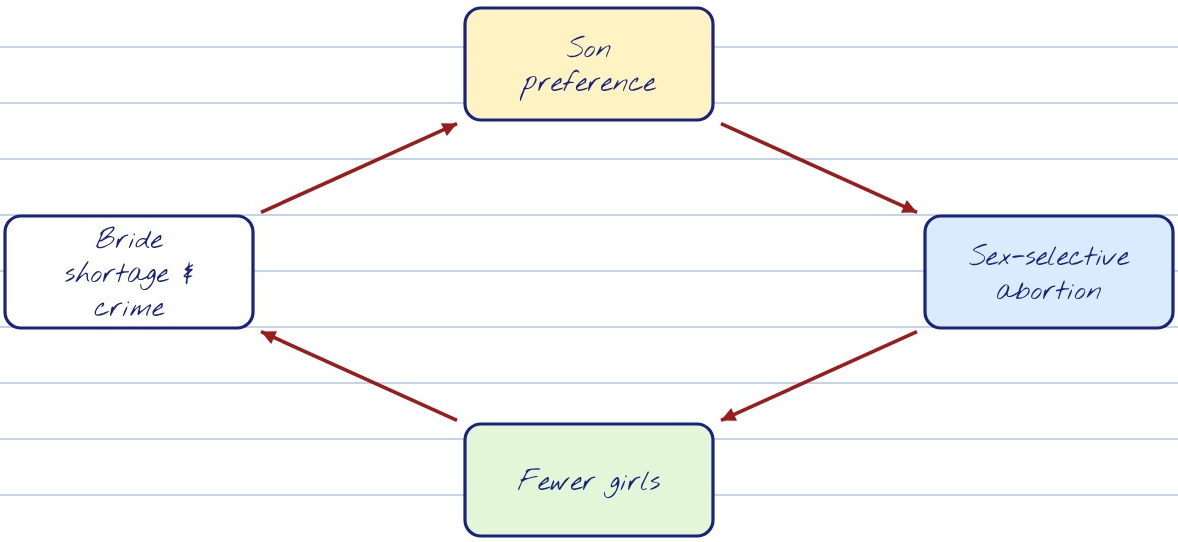
› **Increase in crimes** : trafficking, kidnapping, harassment, sexual violence.

› **Change of family structure** : late marriage of men, more single men, ageing without care.

› **Social unrest** : competition, aggression, weak community ties.

› **Impact on population growth** : fewer mothers -> falling birth rate in future.

› **Violation of right to life** of girls (Art. 21, CEDAW).



Way forward

› Strict implementation of PCPNDT, awareness campaigns, community watch.

› Equal inheritance, end dowry, economic security for women (old-age support by daughters).

› Education, positive media images, incentives for girl child.

9. The Gender Spectrum

Gender spectrum : gender is a continuum rather than two boxes - people can sit anywhere along it, move across it, or reject labels altogether.



Q12. Explain the gender spectrum and why it is important.

Ans. It shows that masculinity and femininity are not opposite ends of one line but traits available to all.

- Gender identity (who I am), expression (how I show it), assigned sex (body) and attraction are **four separate dimensions.**
- Recognising the spectrum ends stigma, supports transgender and queer persons and widens freedom for everyone.

Term	Meaning
Cisgender	Identity matches sex assigned at birth
Transgender	Identity differs from sex at birth
Non-binary	Not exclusively man or woman
Gender-fluid	Identity changes over time
Gender dysphoria	Distress when body and identity differ
Queer	Umbrella term for non-heteronormative identities

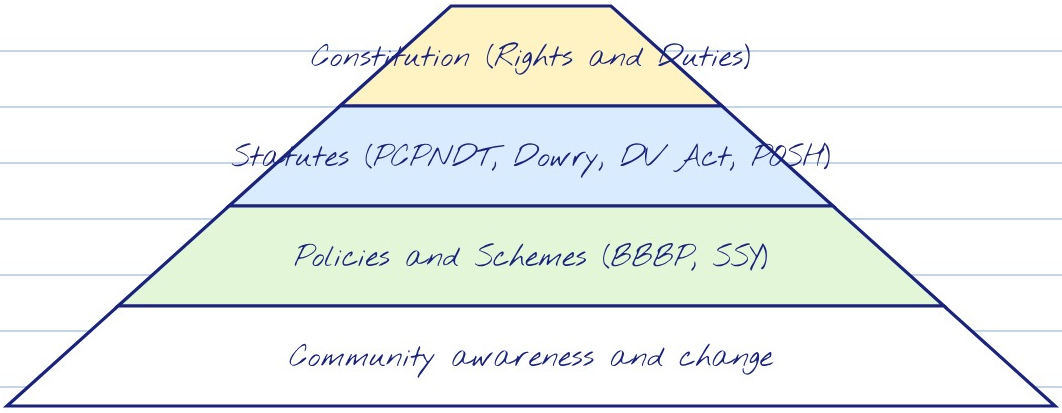
Q13. Mention Key rights of transgender persons in India.

- Right to self-perceived gender identity; certificate of identity (Act of 2019).
- No discrimination in education, employment, health, housing; welfare board and special measures.
- Offences : forced begging, denial of access to public places, physical or sexual abuse are punishable.

10. Constitutional and Legal Provisions for Gender Equality

Q14. List constitutional provisions that support gender equality in India.

Article	Provision
Art. 14	Equality before law, equal protection of laws
Art. 15(1), 15(3)	No discrimination on sex, special provisions for women and children
Art. 16	Equal opportunity in public employment
Art. 21	Right to life with dignity (includes privacy, safety)
Art. 39(a), (d)	Adequate livelihood, equal pay for equal work (DPSP)
Art. 42	Just and humane work conditions, maternity relief
Art. 51A(e)	Fundamental duty : renounce practices derogatory to women
Art. 243D, 243T	One-third seats for women in Panchayats and Municipalities



Q15. What is the difference between sex ratio and child sex ratio? Why is CSR more alarming?

Ans. Sex ratio counts all ages; CSR counts only children 0-6 years, so it shows the direct effect of sex selection at birth.

- Overall sex ratio can rise because women live longer, hiding the problem; CSR falling means fewer girls are even born.

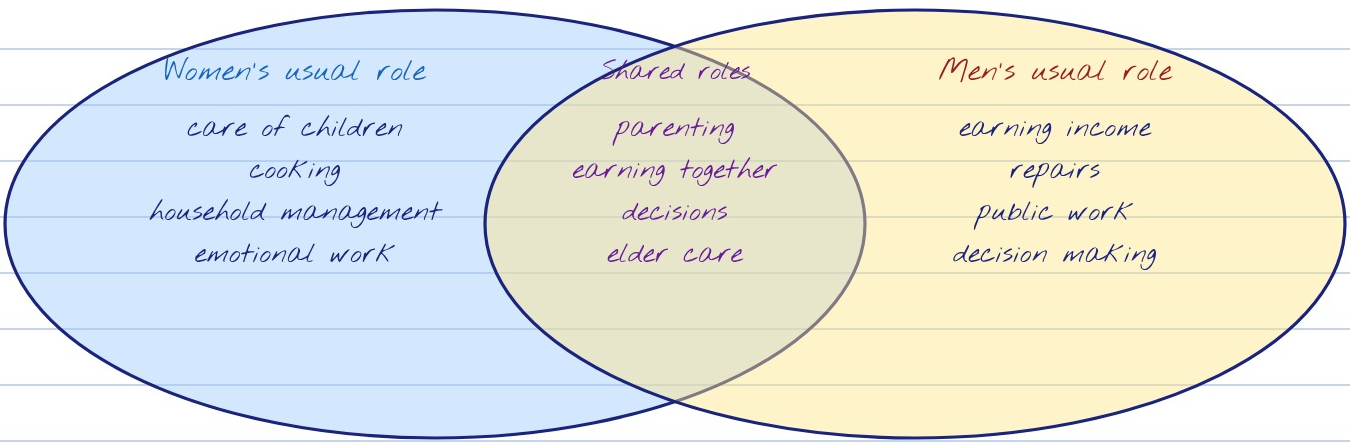
II. Case Study and Discussion

Case study : "Only a son"

- Sunita has two daughters. Her in-laws pressure her for a third child and ask a clinic for a scan to check the sex.
- Identify : son preference, patriarchy, illegal sex determination (PCPNDT), violation of her bodily autonomy.
- Suggest : inform the Appropriate Authority, counselling, awareness that daughters can also be heirs and caregivers, schemes for girl child.

Q16. How do gender roles hurt men too?

- Men must be provider and protector; those who cry, care or stay at home are ridiculed.
- Higher rates of stress, addiction, suicide and risky behaviour; less time with children.
- Rigid roles limit everyone; sharing roles gives a happier, equal family.



12. Objective and Long Questions

Q17. Quick choice

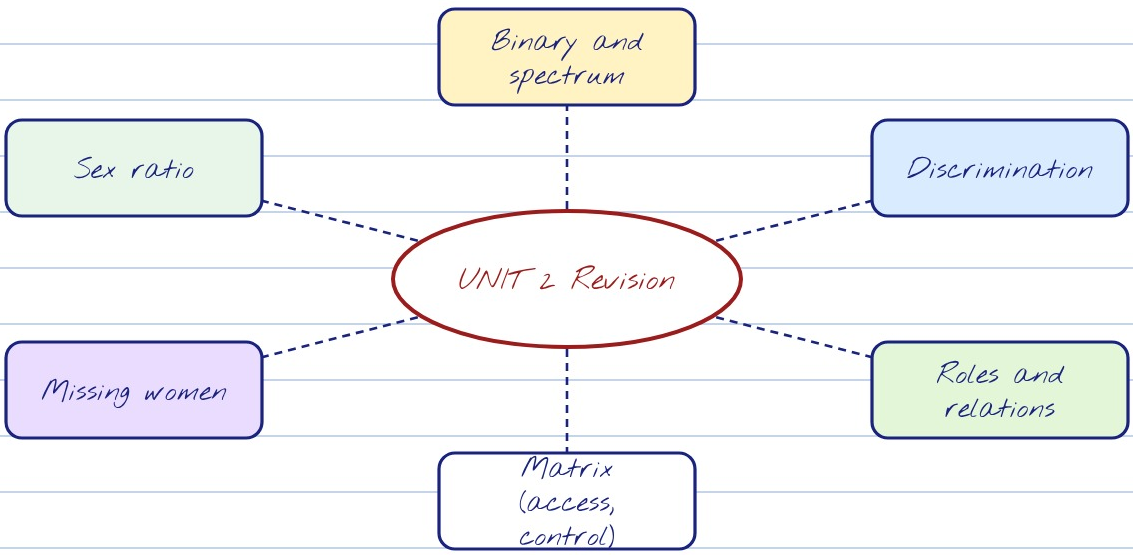
> 1. Female per 1000 male = **sex ratio**. 2. "Missing women" – **Amartya Sen**.
> 3. PCPNDT Act year = **1994**. 4. CSR 2011 = **919**. 5. Third gender recognised in **NALSA (2014)**.
> 6. Unpaid cooking & caring = **reproductive role**.

Q18. Long answers (10 marks)

> 1. Discuss "Two or Many?" and the gender spectrum. (Sec. 1, 9)
> 2. Explain types of gender roles and the roles-relationship matrix. (Sec. 3, 4)
> 3. Causes, consequences and remedies of sex selection and declining sex ratio. (Sec. 5–8)
> 4. Describe struggles against gender discrimination in India. (Sec. 2)

Gender roles can be changed – gender relations must be made EQUAL.

13. Two-Mark Questions and Quick Revision



Q19. Two-mark questions

> 1. **Gender relations** : power relations between women and men in access to resources and decisions.
> 2. **Productive role** : paid or income-generating work; **reproductive role** : unpaid care and housework.
> 3. **Sex ratio** : females per 1000 males; **CSR** : in age 0–6 years.
> 4. **Missing women** : women lost due to neglect, selective abortion, infanticide (Amartya Sen).
> 5. **Intersex** : born with sex traits not fitting male or female boxes.
> 6. **Glass ceiling** : invisible barrier stopping women from reaching top positions.
> 7. **Double burden** : paid job plus unpaid housework done by women.

> 8. **PCPNDT Act** : bans pre-natal sex determination and sex-selective abortion.

Concept	One-line memory aid
Roles	What we DO (can swap)
Relations	Who has POWER (must equalise)
Access vs Control	Use vs Decide
Spectrum	Many positions, not two boxes